As India is now a full member of the SCO, expectations from the Central Asia states will rise, and they will compare India with China.

Eighth, stakes are particularly high for India with regard to securing energy and connectivity interests. As both India and Pakistan have become members, connectivity and energy corridor projects such as the Central Asia–South Asia hydropower project (CASA-1000 power transmission project),[9] Turkmenistan–Afghanistan–Pakistan–India (TAPI) pipeline,[10] Iran–Pakistan–India (IPI) pipeline,[11] and others might finally see the light at the end of the tunnel.

India’s entry elusive

India’s attempt at entering the SCO as a full member remained elusive for a long time. Although member states such as Russia, Kazakhstan, and Tajikistan firmly supported India’s inclusion into the SCO,[12] China and others pushed for a more “process-bound” entry of new members. The delay in granting full membership to India (and Pakistan and Iran) into the SCO was caused by several factors. One reason was the lack of criteria, procedures, and timeline. Another was that the grouping had always entertained some reservations about the entry of South Asian countries. While Russia pushed India’s case, and China pressed for Pakistan’s entry, the SCO as a group feared that it would get mired in a South Asian conflict between India and Pakistan. Moreover, some saw India’s proclivity as being towards the East and West rather than Eurasia.

It was very apparent that China, being the SCO’s ultimate boss, strongly opposed India’s entry, and that if India’s membership were to come through, it would have to come with a great many prescribed terms and conditions. The